Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

Is a Graphic Design Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

8.4

AI EXPOSURE · PRODUCTION / EXECUTION DESIGN

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. This matters more here than in any other profile in the index.

Because this is the one where the news is genuinely hard, and where the person reading it has probably built part of their identity around being the creative one. A teenager who has spent five years being told they're talented does not need a document telling them the market disagrees. They need to understand that the field split, and which part of it to aim for.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. It is also not a case for giving up on design. The protected end of this field is real, it is well paid, and it is reachable — but it has to be aimed at deliberately from the start rather than drifted into.

One request. If your instinct on reading the score is "I told them to do something sensible," please don't say it. The most useful thing you can do with this document is help them steer, not confirm a worry.

The short answer

Not for production work. A design degree aimed at making assets is the single riskiest path in this index.

Production and execution design scores **8.4** out of 10 — the highest score of any career we measure. Creative direction scores **5.6**, and UX and product design **6.0**.

And here is what makes design different from every other exposed career in this index. Everywhere else, the automatable layer is the administrative shell around the work — nurses chart, doctors write notes, teachers mark. Automation removes something people resented.

In design, the automatable layer is the craft.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Creative direction / brand identity	4.8	5.2	**5.6**	+0.8	Moderate
UX / product design	5.2	5.6	**6.0**	+0.8	Moderate
Motion, 3D & technical craft	5.9	6.5	**7.0**	+1.1	Moderate–High
Illustration / commercial art	6.3	7.0	**7.5**	+1.2	High
Production / execution design	6.7	7.8	**8.4**	+1.7	**Highest in the index**

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, entry-level software development scores 8.1, content marketing 8.2, and general document translation 8.8.

Read the table this way: production design moved +1.7 in three years from an already elevated base, and it sits above entry-level software development. The gap between the top and bottom of this profession is 2.8 points.

Why design scores so high — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	**9.1**
How hard will it be to land that first job?	**8.0**
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	**1.0**
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	**3.0**
Does the law require a licensed human?	**1.0**
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	**3.0**

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how production and execution design answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

We rate this 9.1 — the highest rating we assign on any factor to any career in this index.

Image generation and asset creation. Layout, resizing and format variants. Routine illustration and stock work. Banner, social and ad production. Mockups and visual iteration. Photo retouching and cleanup.

Section 4 explains why a 9.1 here means something different from a 9.1 anywhere else.

What resists: deciding what a brand should mean, art direction with intent, taste as a decision-making function, and defending a creative decision to a board.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe.

Production and asset work was the entry tier — the work junior designers did while learning judgment. It is now the most automated work in this index.

Junior roles have also shifted in what they ask for. 32% of design job listings now mention AI tools such as Midjourney, Firefly or DALL·E, up from 3% in 2023, and 67% require Figma, up from 30% in 2021. The skill floor moved in under three years.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it, unless the physical object is the point — signage, print production, furniture, ceramics. Those are genuinely different careers.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At creative direction level meaningfully; at production level not at all.

A client betting a rebrand on someone's judgment wants a human accountable for it. Nobody is accountable for a resized banner.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No, and none is coming. There is no design licence, no reserved activity, no professional body controlling entry.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At direction level often; at production level rarely. A brand strategy for a company entering an unfamiliar market is genuine novelty. Producing forty variants of an approved asset is the opposite.

When the automatable layer *is* the craft

This is the most important section in the profile, and the argument generalises beyond design.

Everywhere else in this index, automation removes the shell around the work.

Nurses chart. Doctors write notes and letters. Teachers plan and mark. Lawyers draft. Engineers document. In every one of those cases, the automatable layer is the part people resented, and removing it returns time to the thing they trained for.

Design is the exception.

Making the image. Building the layout. Producing the asset. That was not the paperwork around design — it *was* design. It's what people spend years learning to do well, and it's the part that made the job feel like a craft.

That's what a 9.1 means here. Not that the profession is worthless, but that the specific activity most designers spend most of their day performing is now something a non-designer can do adequately in seconds.

We rate it 9.1 rather than 10 because output quality still varies enormously with the skill of the person directing it, and because professional-standard work still requires judgment about what "good" looks like. But that judgment is a *directing* skill, not a *making* skill — and directing is a smaller job that fewer people are needed for.

This is also why creative direction sits at 5.6 rather than 8.4. Direction was never the automatable layer. It was always taste, intent and accountability, and none of those have moved much.

The general lesson, and it applies well beyond design: ask whether the automatable part of a job is the part you would enjoy. In most professions it isn't, and automation is a gift. In this one it is, and that changes the honest advice from "the field is fine" to "the field is fine and the job you pictured may not be."

The evidence that the split is already official

We'd normally put labour-market data in a later section. Here it belongs up front, because it independently confirms the central finding of this profile — and it comes from the US government rather than from us.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics tracks two separate occupational categories:

BLS CATEGORY	PROJECTED GROWTH 2024–2034	MEDIAN WAGE
Graphic Designers (SOC 27-1024)	**+2%** — slower than average	$61,300
Web and Digital Interface Designers (SOC 15-1255)	**+7%** — much faster than average	roughly 60% higher

Same underlying skills. Different category. A 60% wage premium and more than triple the growth rate.

And the BLS says the quiet part out loud. Its own occupational outlook notes that *automated design tools, such as artificial intelligence, may reduce the need for companies to contract with freelance graphic designers*. Federal statistical agencies do not usually name a technology as a headwind for a specific occupation.

Corroborating it: the World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025, surveying over 1,000 employers across 55 countries, flagged graphic designer among the fastest-declining job titles.

So the split this profile describes is not a prediction. It is already embedded in how the government counts the work.

What the trend shows

Production design: 6.7 → 7.8 → 8.4. Up 1.7 in three years, from a base that was already high.

Creative direction: 4.8 → 5.2 → 5.6. Up 0.8.

The gap widened from 1.9 points to 2.8. What is distinctive about design is that the movement started earlier and from higher. Most careers in this index show a step change after 2023. Design was already at 6.7 in 2023, because image generation reached commercial usability before text generation reached the professions.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at direction level	**Durable**	Clients want a person answerable for a brand decision. Commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at direction level	**Eroding slowly**	Taste and intent resist; execution does not.
Regulatory / licensing	**None**	n/a	No licence exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	**None**	n/a	Except where the object is the point — print, signage, craft.

The honest read. Design has two protections, both seniority-dependent, neither inherited from the profession. A graduate has neither, and the route to acquiring them ran through the production work that has been automated.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Making the asset	Directing generation, then selecting and refining
Producing options	Choosing between fifty generated options
Learning taste by executing badly and being corrected	Learning taste by… curating? Nobody knows yet
Charging for time spent	Charging for judgment — a different business model
Deciding what the brand means	**Unchanged**

Two things worth naming.

The pricing model breaks. Design has historically been sold by time or by asset. When producing an asset takes minutes, the economics of the whole freelance market change — which is why the

AIGA and Fast Company have run a pricing transparency study rather than a hiring one.

And the training problem is acute here. Designers built taste by making a great deal of mediocre work and being told why it was mediocre. If the making is automated, the correction loop that produced judgment is missing, and nobody has replaced it.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Taste as a decision** — knowing which of a thousand generated options is right for this

> brand, this market, this moment. The core of what survives.

2. **Intent** — being able to say why, and defend it. 3. **Accountability for a creative choice** — standing behind it when someone senior pushes back. 4. **Understanding a business problem** — most bad design is a misunderstood brief rather than

> a poorly executed one.

5. **Directing generation precisely** — a genuine skill, and now explicitly named in a third of

> job listings.

Notably absent: software fluency, production speed, and volume of polished work. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior designer and are the fastest-depreciating things in the field.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The industry is growing even as the job title contracts, and both things are true at once. Design services revenue continues to expand; what has changed is how much human production it requires per dollar.

- **Creative directors report a median around $138,000**, and the senior end of this field is genuinely well paid
- **UX and product designers out-earn graphic designers substantially** — the roughly 60% BLS premium, and industry surveys put the gap higher still
- **Specialisation pays:** freelance specialists report earning materially more than generalists
- **About 20,000 openings a year** are still projected for graphic designers, mostly from turnover rather than growth
- **Roughly one in five designers is self-employed**, which is high, and autonomy is one of the field's genuine attractions

And a finding worth sitting with. The 2026 Freelance Design Pricing study, run by Fast Company with AIGA across 1,426 respondents, found nearly 40% of companies now use AI to start creative projects — but only 14% of hiring managers expect their need for freelance designers to shrink.

That gap is the most encouraging data point in this profile. It suggests AI is being used at the *beginning* of the process rather than instead of it — though it is a forecast by hiring managers rather than an observed outcome, and should be read as such.

What designers report as rewarding: making things that exist in the world and that people encounter, solving a communication problem elegantly, and the specific satisfaction of craft — which is precisely the part under pressure.

What's genuinely hard about it

The entry tier has been hollowed out, and it was the training ground.

The pricing model is under real strain. When production is fast and cheap, hourly billing collapses and value-based pricing requires a seniority and confidence most juniors don't have.

Portfolio expectations have inverted. Volume of polished work used to be the signal. Volume is now free, so a portfolio full of beautiful assets says nothing. What signals value is evidence of judgment — why this direction, what was rejected, what happened when it shipped.

And the emotional dimension is real and worth naming. People go into design because they love making things. Being told the making is the automated part lands differently from being told your paperwork is automated.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Design tends to suit people who:

- **Are interested in the problem, not just the artefact** — the single best predictor of who moves up rather than out
- **Can take criticism of work they care about**, repeatedly, without deflating
- **Can explain a choice**, not just make it. The whole protected end depends on this.
- **Are commercially curious** — design serves a business objective, and the designers who understand that get to direct

It's harder for people who:

- **Love the craft itself above all** — this is the honest one, and it's the group most affected
- Find **defending decisions** uncomfortable
- Want **stable, definable tasks**
- Are drawn to design as an escape from analytical work; the surviving end of this field is more analytical, not less

What else is moving this market

The tooling consolidated fast. Figma requirements went from 30% of listings in 2021 to 67% today. Sketch collapsed, InVision closed. The tool landscape is now stable in a way it wasn't.

Offshoring compounds automation at the production tier, as it does in accounting.

And the category migration is the thing to watch. Designers increasingly identify as UX, product, motion or interactive designers — categories BLS counts separately and projects growing. That migration is the profession's own answer to this problem, and it is already well underway.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: design was the first creative profession to be substantially affected, which means it is also furthest into working out what comes next. That's an advantage for someone entering now.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE DESIGNER LOOKS LIKE

1. Direct precisely. Getting usable output requires knowing what to ask for, which requires knowing what good looks like. A third of job listings now name this explicitly.

2. Curate with judgment. Choosing among generated options is the job now, and choosing well is a real and scarce skill.

3. Articulate the why. Being able to defend a creative decision to a client or a board. This is the whole protected end of the field expressed as a skill.

4. Understand the business problem. The designers who get to direct are the ones who understand what the work is for, rather than only how it should look.

5. Price judgment rather than time. The old model breaks when production is instant. Learning to sell outcomes rather than hours is a commercial skill the profession is actively rebuilding.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: aim at UX, product or direction from the start rather than assuming a production job leads there. That progression is the specific thing that has broken.

During: build a portfolio of *decisions*, not assets. For every piece, be able to say what the problem was, what you rejected, and what happened. Learn to present and defend work — most programmes underweight this and it's the protected skill.

And take the adjacent seriously: research methods, basic analytics, a domain. Design paired with healthcare, accessibility or industrial contexts is far more defensible than design alone.

The routes in

ROUTE	ASSESSMENT
Design degree aimed at direction and concept	Works. Look for programmes built around brief, rationale and critique rather than software.
UX / product design pathway	The strongest position in the field. BLS projects the category growing 7%.
Design + a domain — health, accessibility, industrial	The domain is the protection.
Craft where the object is the point — print, signage, furniture, ceramics	Physical protection reappears here. Different career, genuinely different score.
General design degree aimed at production work	The weakest combination in this index.

Where a design degree can take them later

Broader than people assume: creative direction and brand strategy, UX and product design, design leadership, design research, motion and 3D, art direction, design operations, and founding a studio.

The pattern in this index holds precisely: roles where someone decides and is answerable score better; roles that produce what someone else decided score worse. In design that distinction is unusually stark, because the producing has become close to free.

What to look for in a design program

1. Is it built around concept or software? A curriculum organised by tool is training for the automated tier. One organised around brief, rationale and critique is training for the protected one.

2. How much critique, and how rigorous? Defending decisions is the protected skill. Programmes vary enormously in how seriously they teach it.

3. Is there a UX or product pathway? Given the BLS category split, this matters more than the school's reputation.

4. Real client work. Live briefs with actual constraints and actual feedback.

5. First-destination job titles. Not "employed in a creative field." What are they *doing*?

Questions to ask a design program

On the curriculum:

- Is the programme organised around software or around design thinking and rationale?
- How much formal critique do students get, and from whom?
- Is there a UX or product design pathway, and how many students take it?

On AI:

- How does the programme teach students to work with generative tools?

- How has the curriculum changed in the last two years? What specifically?
- What does the programme now consider a strong portfolio?

On outcomes:

- What job titles did last year's graduates hold at six months?
- What proportion are in UX, product or direction roles rather than production?

Red flags: a curriculum organised by software package; minimal critique; no UX pathway; outcomes described as "working in the creative industries"; a portfolio standard that still rewards volume.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Graphic Designers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. The primary source, free, and unusually direct: it names automated design tools as a factor reducing demand for freelance designers. Read it alongside the separate **Web and Digital Interface Designers** entry, and note the difference in projected growth. That comparison is the single most useful thing in this profile.

- **Freelance design in 2026: how to set fees, wrangle clients, and navigate AI** — *Fast Company with* AIGA, 1,426 respondents including 153 hiring companies. The source of the 40%-versus-14% finding, and the best available picture of what is actually happening to design pricing.

- **Is graphic design a good career in 2026?** — a careful, sourced treatment of the BLS category split and what it means in practice. Note it's published by a design college, so read the framing critically — but the underlying data is cited properly.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our 8.4 is historical, and it has a good record.
>
> When desktop publishing arrived, designers feared replacement by "anyone with a mouse." The field expanded instead, and produced entirely new subfields — UX, digital branding, product design — that hadn't previously existed. On this reading, generative AI is the next iteration of a tool shift the profession has repeatedly absorbed, and our score mistakes a transition for a collapse.

> There's live evidence for it too: nearly 40% of companies use AI to start creative projects, and only 14% of hiring managers expect to need fewer freelance designers.
>
> **Where we land:** we take it seriously, and it's part of why direction sits at 5.6 rather than 8. But there's a difference worth naming between a tool that changes *how* work is produced and one that produces the work itself. Photoshop still needed a designer at the keyboard for every asset. Generation does not.
>
> The honest position is that we don't know whether new creative categories will appear fast enough to absorb the displaced production tier. History says probably something will, and offers no guarantee about timing. **A graduate needs a job in the meantime, and the transition is exactly when the pain lands.**

Bottom line

Design is the most exposed career in this index, and it is not a dead end.

Those two statements sit together uncomfortably, and both are true. Production work — the thing most people picture when they say "graphic designer" — scores 8.4 and is the most automated professional work we measure. Creative direction at 5.6 and UX at 6.0 are real, well-paid, growing careers.

The government's own data already reflects the split. Graphic Designers projected to grow 2%; Web and Digital Interface Designers 7%, at roughly a 60% wage premium. The migration between those categories is the answer, and it's already happening.

What makes design genuinely different is the emotional shape of it. In most professions automation takes the part people resented. Here it takes the craft — the thing that made the job feel worth doing. That's worth acknowledging honestly rather than reframing as opportunity.

So the useful advice isn't "don't study design." It's: aim at direction, UX or a domain pairing from the start rather than assuming production work leads there, build a portfolio of decisions rather than assets, learn to defend choices because that's the protected skill, and treat commercial understanding as core rather than optional.

And one thing worth saying to a seventeen-year-old who loves making things. The judgment about what should exist is now worth more than the ability to make it, and that judgment is built by people who care about craft. The path is narrower than it was. It hasn't closed.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made design appealing? Push past "I'm creative" to something specific. 2. **Do they love the making, or the problem?** This is the most important question here, and the answers lead to very different places. 3. What does a Tuesday look like in the job they're imagining? 4. Can they take criticism of work they care about? Repeatedly, and without deflating?

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Production design scores 8.4 — the highest in the index — and creative direction 5.6. How does that land? 6. The profile says that in design, unlike everywhere else, the automatable part *is* the craft. Does that match what they've seen? 7. BLS projects Graphic Designers growing 2% and Web and Digital Interface Designers 7%. Does that change what they'd aim at?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. **Be careful with this one.** Has anyone told them design is a bad idea? What did that feel like, and what would actually be useful from you instead? 9. The route from production work up to direction is the part that's broken. What's their plan for getting to the protected end? 10. Portfolios used to reward volume. Volume is now free. Does their portfolio show *decisions*?

Part 2c — The other side

11. Of what designers find rewarding — making things people encounter, solving communication problems, craft itself — which matters most? The answer is genuinely diagnostic here. 12. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then compare. 13. Can they explain *why* a design choice is right, or only that it is? That skill is the whole protected end.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

14. A third of design job listings now name AI tools. Have they used them seriously — not as a novelty, but to try to produce something good? 15. Designers used to build taste by making bad work and being corrected. If the making is automated, how do they think taste gets built now?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

16. **The most valuable single action:** find a designer two to three years in and ask what they actually do all day, and what changed in the last eighteen months. 17. Can they get a real brief — a small business, a charity, a school project with an actual client? Real constraints teach what studio work cannot.

Part 4 — About the program

18. Ask each programme the curriculum questions from section 14. Whether it's organised around software or around thinking is the whole answer. 19. Is there a UX or product pathway, and how many students take it? 20. What job titles do graduates hold at six months?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

21. Have they looked at **UX and product design** specifically, as opposed to graphic design? Same instincts, materially better position. 22. What about design paired with a domain — healthcare, accessibility, industrial? 23. If the physical object is what they love, have they considered craft where that's the point — print, signage, furniture, ceramics? The physical protection reappears there.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

24. **What's my honest reaction to this score, and am I about to say something I shouldn't?** 25. Have I ever been dismissive about design as a career? They'll remember it. 26. Can I help them steer rather than confirm a worry? That's the only useful role available here. 27. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. For design specifically, we've published the historical counterargument in full because it has a good track record, and we don't know whether it applies this time.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Graphic & Visual Design

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

```
Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-seven careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No licence exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

CREATIVE DIRECTION / BRAND IDENTITY — 5.6 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.9	**5.9**	2.06
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	**4.5**	0.67
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.25
				Total	**5.62 → 5.6**

UX / PRODUCT DESIGN — 6.0 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.6	5.5	**6.4**	2.24
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.5	**5.0**	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.3
				Total	**5.99 → 6.0**

MOTION, 3D & TECHNICAL CRAFT — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.3	6.7	**7.8**	2.73
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.8	**6.5**	0.97
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.45
				Total	**7.01 → 7.0**

ILLUSTRATION / COMMERCIAL ART — 7.5 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	7.1	**8.2**	2.87
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.5	**7.2**	1.08
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.55
				Total	**7.5 → 7.5**

PRODUCTION / EXECUTION DESIGN — 8.4 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	7.4	**8.7**	3.04
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	8.0	**9.0**	1.35
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	3.0	3.0	**3.0**	1.05
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	**1.0**	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.0	3.0	**3.0**	0.7
				Total	**8.39 → 8.4**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Creative direction / brand identity

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.0	3.5	2.88	**4.8**
2025	4.9	4.0	2.88	**5.2**
Fall 2026	5.9	4.5	2.88	**5.6**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.67** and entry-path erosion **+0.15**, for a total of **+0.8** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labour market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.